

The Wishing Index

Allen Girls Adventures

Allen Girls Adventures · Library Labyrinth Edition

Chapter 1 — The Drawer That Hummed

Rain tapped softly against the stained-glass windows of the library when Maya heard it first: a tiny humming under the card catalog like a bee that had learned to whisper. She crouched, pressed her ear to the oak drawers, and grinned. "Treasure noise," she said.

Alana pushed her glasses up and opened her field notebook. "Or vibration from a loose shelf brace," she said, already curious. She believed mysteries were better when measured. Natalia walked over more slowly, hand resting on the smooth wood as if greeting an old friend. SPARK rolled beside them, antenna flickering blue.

"Acoustic profile confirms harmonic resonance," SPARK announced. "Not mechanical. Not insect. Possibly magical bureaucracy."

Maya tugged a brass handle and slid open Drawer Q. Instead of dusty cards, a warm glow spilled out. Inside lay a neat stack of library cards edged in gold, each one blank except for one line at the top: WISH REQUEST. At the bottom, in tiny ink, it read: Borrow fairly. Return fully.

"A wishing system with conditions," Alana murmured. "Excellent."

Natalia lifted the top card. "What does return fully mean?"

SPARK projected a small diagram in the air. "Hypothesis: any granted wish creates a temporary imbalance. User must restore equivalent value."

Maya had already grabbed a pencil from behind her ear. "Easy. I wish for ten mango popsicles."

"Bold as always," Natalia said, smiling.

Maya wrote the wish. The card warmed in her hand, then flashed once like a camera. A frosty paper bag appeared beside her sneaker with a polite plop. Ten mango popsicles, perfectly wrapped, all labeled "Property of Imagination Cold Storage."

Maya squealed. Alana checked one with a thermometer strip from her pocket. "Minus eight degrees. Real enough."

Then the card flipped itself and wrote new words:

RETURN DUE: SHARE JOY EQUIVALENT TO TEN POPSICLES.

Maya blinked. "How do I return joy?"

"By making ten people smile because of this wish," Natalia guessed.

SPARK beeped approval. "Ethical reciprocity detected."

They looked at each other. A wishing catalog hidden in the library. Wishes that worked. Wishes that expected responsibility.

Maya licked mango ice from her thumb and stood up. "Okay," she said. "We can do this. We just need a system."

Alana was already sketching columns: Wish, Outcome, Return Task, Verification.

Natalia slipped the glowing card into a folder and held it like a promise. "Then let us borrow carefully."

The drawer hummed louder, as if pleased that someone had finally listened.

SPARK tilted his antenna. "Recommendation: proceed to Chapter Two."

Chapter 2 — Borrowers of Wonder

By afternoon, the four friends had built a command station in the reading nook. Alana taped graph paper to the table, SPARK projected checklists over it, and Natalia wrote a gentle heading across the top: WISH LOG - BORROW AND RETURN. Maya decorated the corners with tiny doodles of stars wearing librarian glasses.

"Rule one," Alana said, tapping the paper. "No wish without a return plan."

"Rule two," Natalia added. "No wish that harms anyone."

"Rule three," Maya said, holding up a popsicle like a wand. "If it sounds too selfish, we rewrite it."

SPARK chimed. "Rule four: archive all anomalies for future readers."

They tested the catalog with small wishes first. Alana wished for a magnifying lens that could reveal invisible ink in old manuscripts. It appeared in a velvet case with silver hinges.

RETURN DUE: TEACH THREE OTHERS TO NOTICE HIDDEN THINGS.

Natalia wished for a bookmark that would hold not only pages, but feelings, so she could return to brave paragraphs when she needed them. A thin ribbon of midnight-blue silk appeared, threaded with tiny stitched constellations.

RETURN DUE: LEAVE COMFORTING NOTES IN FIVE BOOKS.

SPARK, after a long pause, wished for "a translation patch for whale songs in story form." A small prism clipped itself to his antenna.

RETURN DUE: SHARE ONE NEW SONG WITH THE LIBRARY.

Maya wished for courage boots "for days when knees wobble." Scarlet lace-up boots appeared, warm as sunshine.

RETURN DUE: STAND UP FOR SOMEONE BEFORE SUNSET.

None of the wishes were huge. None changed the world in fireworks. But each came with a thread tying magic to kindness. The catalog was less a vending machine and more a lesson.

They spent the day repaying. Maya helped a shy first-grader retrieve a high shelf book and defended him when older kids laughed at his dinosaur backpack. Return complete. Natalia tucked five handwritten notes into random novels: You are not behind. Keep going. Someone is cheering for you. Return complete. Alana taught three younger readers to use the lens and find hidden initials in antique margins. Return complete.

At dusk, SPARK climbed onto a stool by the open window and played a soft synthesized melody shaped by whale-song patterns. Readers nearby looked up and smiled without knowing why.

"Return complete," SPARK said quietly.

When they checked the cards, each one glowed green and slid itself into a new slot labeled BALANCED.

Natalia touched the drawer frame. "It is keeping score, but not to punish us."

"To teach stewardship," Alana corrected, pleased.

Maya leaned against them both. "Best homework ever."

The deepest drawer clicked open by itself.

Inside waited more cards, and one question written in curling ink: WHAT WILL YOU BORROW NEXT?

Chapter 3 — The Wish That Ran Ahead

The next morning, Maya arrived first and found Alana already reading by the card catalog, hair clipped back and pencil in hand. Natalia followed with cocoa in a thermos for everyone, and SPARK trundled in carrying a tiny tray of labeled index dividers.

"Today we test a medium-scale wish," Alana said. "Controlled conditions."

Maya grinned. "I love when your science words sound like adventure words."

They selected a card and debated possibilities. New paint for the reading room? A self-shelving cart? Extra time before homework? Finally Natalia suggested something simple and generous.

"What if we wish for everyone in the library to find exactly the book they need today?"

Silence settled, warm and thoughtful.

"That is elegant," SPARK said. "Potentially large ripple."

They wrote the wish together, each holding the pencil for one word. The card flashed. Somewhere in the stacks, wheels squeaked, pages fluttered, and several readers gasped at once as if they had found old friends on shelves.

Then the return appeared:

RETURN DUE: RE-SHELVING ALL MISPLACED BOOKS BEFORE MOONRISE.

Maya whistled. "That could be a thousand books."

"Seven hundred and nineteen visible from here," SPARK said after a rapid scan.

Alana did not panic. She drew a map. "We divide by section. Natalia coordinates check-in carts. Maya does rapid retrieval. SPARK tracks progress in real time."

The work was hard and hilarious. Maya climbed ladders like a pirate captain reclaiming treasure. Natalia sorted towers of books with patient accuracy, reading each spine carefully before placing it in proper order. Alana handled cross-category oddities and corrected shelving errors with cheerful precision. SPARK projected glowing arrows across the aisles and issued encouraging updates.

"Current status: 43 percent complete. Team morale: spicy but stable."

By evening their arms ached. Dust sparkled in sunset beams. A final pile remained: books with missing labels, bent call numbers, and mystery placements from years of hurried returns.

Natalia sat on the floor beside the pile. "These are the ones no one knew where to put."

"Then we make room," Maya said.

They created a temporary shelf titled STILL FINDING HOME and logged each book for future repair. It felt right, like giving uncertain things a safe place instead of forcing them where they did not belong.

At moonrise, the final card glowed green. The catalog hummed once, long and low, like a satisfied cello note.

Alana leaned back against the shelf and laughed tiredly. "Conclusion: large wishes require large care."

Natalia nodded. "And care can be a kind of wish, too."

SPARK's chest screen displayed one line:

BALANCE ACHIEVED. ADVANCED CARDS UNLOCKED.

Chapter 4 — The Borrower's Oath

The advanced cards were black instead of cream, their edges silver, their lettering brighter. Each one carried a tiny symbol in the corner: a feather, a key, an hourglass, a lantern. Natalia noticed another line added beneath the usual

rule.

For borrowers who understand the oath.

"We should probably know the oath before touching those," she said.

SPARK scanned Drawer Q, then the side panel, then the underside where old gum scars lived from less careful decades. "Hidden compartment detected."

Maya whooped and pressed the latch. A narrow panel swung open to reveal a folded vellum sheet tied with blue thread. Alana untied it with reverence. The ink looked old but un-faded, like it had been rewritten every year by invisible hands.

The Borrower's Oath: Take what you need, not what flatters you. Return what you can, not what is easy. Leave the catalog kinder than you found it.

Maya read it twice. "That is... surprisingly strict for magic cards."

"Good systems are strict where values matter," Alana said.

Natalia traced the final line. "Leave it kinder."

They placed hands on the catalog and spoke the oath aloud together. The drawers clicked in sequence, one by one, like dominoes of approval. A new card rose from the deepest slot and floated to Natalia.

Wish Request: help us hear what has been forgotten.

"That sounds less like a wish and more like an assignment," Maya said.

They accepted it anyway.

The card flashed, and sound shifted across the library. At first nothing changed, then tiny murmurs emerged from old corners: neglected atlases whispering their river names, abandoned poetry books reciting opening lines to no one, a torn dictionary muttering missing letters. Forgotten things had been speaking all along.

Return due appeared:

RETURN DUE: RESTORE TEN FORGOTTEN VOICES TO CIRCULATION.

They spent hours finding books no one had checked out in years. Maya made bright recommendation signs with hand-drawn dragons and stars. Alana built a "Try Me" curiosity station with fascinating facts from overlooked nonfiction. Natalia started a quiet table called Found Again, where readers could sample one random neglected title with tea biscuits. SPARK recorded one-minute audio teasers and played them near the entrance.

By closing time, nine forgotten books had been borrowed. One remained: a thick field guide to moths with a

cracked spine and no takers.

Maya held it up dramatically. "Come on, moth book! You deserve your hero moment."

A little boy in a raincoat paused. "Does it have moon moths?"

"Page eighty-two," Alana said instantly.

He checked it out, hugging it to his chest.

The card glowed green.

Natalia smiled at the catalog. "Kinder, then."

The drawers answered with a soft, grateful hum.

Chapter 5 — Alana's Impossible Equation

Two days later, Alana stood at the catalog before anyone else arrived. She held a blank card and stared at it without writing. When Natalia came in, she found her friend unusually quiet, notebook closed.

"What is it?" Natalia asked.

Alana exhaled. "My science fair project. I can design it, run it, explain it. But the presentation part..." She grimaced. "My voice disappears in front of crowds."

Maya burst in moments later, saw Alana's face, and softened. "Wish card?"

Alana nodded. "I was thinking of wishing for confidence."

SPARK rolled up and projected her heart rate, carefully hiding the number behind a privacy blur. "Elevated but manageable."

They discussed the wording for ten full minutes, because words mattered here. Natalia suggested precision. Maya suggested bravery. Alana suggested honesty.

Finally she wrote: I wish for a clear voice when I share what I know.

The card flashed. A tiny brass tuning fork appeared in her palm, warm and surprisingly light.

RETURN DUE: HELP OTHERS FIND THEIR OWN VOICE, NOT YOURS.

Alana swallowed. "That is fair."

They practiced in the astronomy alcove. Alana struck the tuning fork and felt a calm vibration travel up her wrist

like a steadying breath. She presented to Maya first, then Natalia, then SPARK, then two younger students passing by, then an elderly patron who asked excellent follow-up questions about experimental controls.

Between each talk she listened, too. She asked others what they wanted to share and helped them shape one clear sentence each. A shy poet read four lines aloud for the first time. A boy explained his paper bridge design with newfound pride. A janitor described his seed collection like a museum curator.

"Return due probably wants multiplicative effect," Alana said, half-joking.

SPARK displayed a tiny equation in the air:

confidence received x confidence offered = confidence returned.

When science fair day came, Alana trembled at the podium. She touched the tuning fork in her pocket but did not strike it. She looked at her friends in the front row: Maya giving a fierce thumbs-up, Natalia with steady eyes, SPARK holding a sign that read DATA IS BEAUTIFUL.

Alana began. Her voice wavered once, then steadied. She explained her experiment about paper fibers and water absorption with crisp, thoughtful detail. She answered questions clearly, even the tricky one from the strict judge with silver eyebrows.

Afterward she checked her card. Green glow.

But the best part came when three younger students from the library asked if she could help them practice for their own presentations.

Alana smiled. "Yes," she said. "Bring your notes tomorrow."

Maya wrapped an arm around her shoulders. "Impossible equation solved."

Alana corrected her automatically, but softly. "Not impossible. Just multi-step."

Chapter 6 — Maya and the Nearly Selfish Wish

Maya usually knew what she wanted instantly. That morning, standing before the catalog, she did not. She shuffled three cards, chewed her lip, and finally blurted, "I wish I could win the library relay race this Saturday."

The words hung in the air.

Alana tilted her head. "Winning only?"

Natalia's voice was gentle. "What are you hoping winning will give you?"

Maya kicked the table leg lightly. "Everyone says I am loud and wild, not focused. If I win, maybe they stop saying that."

SPARK's chest screen dimmed to listening mode. "Emotional root identified: wanting to be seen accurately."

Maya rubbed out the wish before submitting it. She rewrote slowly: I wish for the focus to run my best race and cheer for others too.

The card flashed. A pair of silver shoelaces appeared, gleaming like moonlight thread.

RETURN DUE: LIFT FIVE RUNNERS WHO WOULD OTHERWISE DROP OUT.

"That is a coach mission," Maya said, eyes widening.

Race day dawned bright and windy. Teams zigzagged through library-themed stations: Quote Dash, Atlas Carry, Silent Sprint, and the dreaded Stairs of Historical Fiction. Maya tied on the silver laces and felt her heartbeat settle into a strong rhythm.

She ran brilliantly in the first leg, but then saw a younger runner trip near the poetry aisle and start crying from embarrassment. Maya could have sprinted ahead. Instead she stopped, helped her up, and jogged beside her to the next marker.

"Breathe with me. In for four, out for four," Maya said.

Later she noticed a teammate panicking over a mixed-up map. She took ten seconds to orient him and sent him off smiling. At the Stairs station she called encouragement to every runner, even rivals.

By the final leg, Maya's team sat in second place. She could still chase first if she pushed hard. She did push hard, legs pumping, braid flying. She finished one heartbeat behind the leader.

Second place.

For one sharp second disappointment stung.

Then five runners she had helped surrounded her, cheering her name louder than the winner's medal announcement. One said, "I only finished because of you." Another said, "You made it fun when I wanted to quit."

Maya laughed, breathless. "Okay, that counts."

That evening the wish card glowed green and added one extra line:

BONUS RETURN: YOU DISCOVERED WHAT YOU WERE REALLY ASKING FOR.

Natalia hugged her. "Seen accurately?"

Maya nodded. "Yeah. Turns out winning is smaller than that."

SPARK recorded the result under: Boldness + kindness = legendary pace.

Chapter 7 — Natalia's Quiet Request

Natalia loved big adventures, but she feared one quiet thing: saying goodbye. Her grandmother's old journal sat half-read in Natalia's bag for weeks because the final pages meant the story would end, and endings felt like tiny losses.

At the catalog she wrote carefully: I wish to finish what I love without fear of the end.

The card warmed, then produced a fountain pen with translucent ink that changed color as it dried.

RETURN DUE: HELP THREE OTHERS COMPLETE A LAST PAGE.

"This one is very you," Maya said softly.

Natalia smiled, unsure but willing.

She started with her own journal. In the sunlit corner by the ferns, she read the final entries aloud to her friends. Her grandmother wrote about ordinary days: tea too strong, jasmine blooming late, one sentence about courage hidden between grocery lists. The final line read, Finish kindly, then begin again.

Natalia cried a little and did not hide it.

"Completion event acknowledged," SPARK said, offering a tissue packet from an internal compartment no one knew he had.

For her return, Natalia noticed endings around her. She helped a younger child write the last paragraph of a fairy tale he had avoided for days. She sat with an older patron who wanted to mail a long-overdue apology letter and feared sealing the envelope. She encouraged Alana to submit her final science fair report instead of endlessly revising.

Each completion felt small and sacred, like setting down a cup without spilling.

At twilight, Natalia returned to the catalog and found her card glowing green, but another card had surfaced beneath it. This one was blank except for a single silver prompt:

WHOSE NAME IS MISSING?

Natalia frowned. "Missing from where?"

SPARK scanned records. "No direct match. Possibly future reference."

Maya peered over her shoulder. "Creepy in a fun way."

Natalia tucked the blank prompt card into her notebook. That night she dreamed of endless card drawers, each containing names written in careful hands. One slot at the very end remained empty, waiting.

In the morning she woke with the dream still bright behind her eyes and told no one yet. Not from secrecy, but from the thoughtful instinct to wait until meaning arrived.

When they met at the library, she opened her grandmother's journal again and copied the last line onto a sticky note for the catalog:

Finish kindly, then begin again.

SPARK read it twice. "This sentence has high durability."

"Good," Natalia said. "I think we will need it."

Chapter 8 — The Debt Storm

The debt storm started on a busy Saturday when three impatient visitors discovered Drawer Q without reading the oath. They wished for instant fame, endless snacks, and a backpack full of exam answers. The wishes appeared, then spun loose like untied balloons.

The catalog alarmed in crimson letters:

UNRETURNED BORROWS ACCUMULATING. BALANCE FAILURE IMMINENT.

Wind rose inside the library, flipping pages and scattering bookmarks like startled birds. Glittering objects appeared and vanished randomly: trophies on top of ladders, cakes in atlas bins, confetti in the quiet zone. Nothing was dangerous yet, but everything was chaotic.

"Debt storm," SPARK said. "Unchecked wishes creating unresolved obligations."

Alana had already opened emergency protocol notes. "We need to convert each unreturned wish into a return task and complete them fast."

Maya chased down the snack wish first, organizing an impromptu sharing table so food reached everyone rather than one backpack. Natalia handled the fame wish, guiding the boastful visitor to help younger readers perform a story recital where everyone got applause. Alana tackled the exam-answer wish by setting up a study station and persuading the student to trade cheating notes for real tutoring.

SPARK tracked debt values in real time, projecting glowing numbers above the catalog.

"Imbalance dropping. Continue moral interventions."

The storm intensified briefly when a glitter cannon exploded inside the biography section. Maya sneezed silver sparkles for ten minutes but kept running.

"I look fabulous and furious!" she shouted.

By sunset, most debt threads had been repaid. Only one remained stubborn: the instant fame wish had left a residue of envy among onlookers.

Natalia stood on a stool and spoke calmly to the small crowd: "A wish can give you a spotlight, but you still choose what to do with it. Let us use this one to celebrate stories that usually go unheard."

She invited readers to share one minute about something they cared about. A gardener described moonflowers. A child explained beetles. A custodian recited a poem he wrote on lunch breaks. Attention spread instead of narrowing.

The final debt number clicked to zero.

The storm dissolved. Pages settled. The red warning faded to warm gold.

The three visitors who had caused the trouble stood sheepish and quiet.

Maya folded her arms, not unkindly. "Read the rules next time."

Alana handed them copied oath cards. "And if you borrow, return."

They nodded. SPARK printed each of them a small checklist titled HOW TO WISH RESPONSIBLY.

When the doors closed, the four friends sat in a glittery heap, exhausted.

"That was intense," Maya said.

"Also instructive," Alana replied.

Natalia looked at Drawer Q, then at her friends. "Magic works best when community is stronger than impulse."

SPARK emitted a tired but proud ping. "Teamwork twist successful."

Chapter 9 — The Blank Card Appears

After the debt storm, the catalog stayed quiet for two days. The friends still visited, still shelved books, still checked on balanced cards, but no new wishes surfaced. It felt like waiting outside a closed door, patient and alert.

On the third evening, just before closing, every drawer slid open one inch at the same time. A low chord filled the room. From the lowest slot, one final card rose slowly and landed in Natalia's hands.

It was completely blank.

No prompt. No lines. No rule text.

Maya leaned close. "Maybe invisible ink?"

Alana scanned with ultraviolet, infrared, and SPARK's spectral filter. Nothing.

"A null template," SPARK said. "Undefined until user declaration."

Natalia's pulse jumped. She remembered the dream of the missing name.

"Maybe this is the last card," she whispered.

Maya reached for a pencil. "Let's wish for something huge. Like library-wide flying carpets."

Natalia gently caught her wrist. "Wait."

She turned the blank card over. At the very edge, barely visible, one embossed phrase shimmered when tilted toward the lamp:

THE FINAL INDEX ENTRY MUST BE SIGNED.

"Signed?" Alana repeated. "With what, exactly?"

SPARK's voice softened. "Likely with identity, not ink."

They debated for an hour. If the card accepted any wish, it could reshape the entire system. If mishandled, it could collapse the balance they had worked so hard to protect. Alana argued for controlled language and explicit safeguards. Maya argued that fear should not freeze them. Natalia listened to both, as she always did, holding tension without rushing.

At last she said, "Maybe the final entry is not about getting something. Maybe it is about declaring how this catalog should serve whoever comes next."

They wrote a draft together:

May this index grant wishes that help borrowers grow in courage, curiosity, and care.

The card stayed blank.

Maya tried adding "and occasional snacks." No response.

Alana added precise constraints and ethical clauses. Still blank.

SPARK projected every known wish syntax. No response.

Then Natalia noticed where her thumb rested near a faint indentation at the bottom right. It looked like a signature line with no label. She lifted the pencil and, heart pounding, wrote her first name softly:

Natalia.

The card blazed with silver light.

New text flooded both sides in curling script:

INDEX KEEPER ACKNOWLEDGED. RETURN DUE: TEACH THE NEXT BORROWER TO WRITE THEIR OWN NAME.

Maya stared. "Whoa."

Alana exhaled in awe. "The last card was waiting for a steward."

SPARK bowed his head slightly. "Congratulations, Natalia."

Natalia held the glowing card with trembling hands. "I did not mean to become important."

Maya squeezed her shoulder. "You were already important."

Chapter 10 — Writing Her Name

Becoming Index Keeper did not give Natalia a crown or secret powers. It gave her responsibility that felt both heavy and right, like carrying a lantern through a dark hallway. The next morning she posted a small sign above Drawer Q:

WISHES WELCOME. OATH REQUIRED. BORROW KINDLY. RETURN FULLY.

Alana helped her draft a clear orientation sheet for new users. Maya volunteered as official first-day greeter with dramatic voice options ("friendly librarian" and "mysterious quest host"). SPARK built a simple guided prompt tool for younger readers.

The first borrower under Natalia's stewardship was a timid girl named Rina who wanted to wish for "being less invisible." She looked ready to run before finishing the sentence.

Natalia knelt to eye level. "You are allowed to take up space," she said. "Let us shape that wish together."

Rina wrote: I wish for the courage to raise my hand once in class this week.

A small amber hair clip appeared, shaped like a sunrise.

RETURN DUE: NOTICE SOMEONE ELSE WHO FEELS INVISIBLE.

Rina read it and nodded slowly. "I can do that."

Over the week, borrowers came with all kinds of desires: mended friendships, steadier concentration, help with grief, one request for a pet dragon that was politely reworded into "confidence while meeting new people." Natalia guided each wish toward growth instead of shortcuts. Alana checked language for loopholes. Maya kept spirits

high and reminded everyone that magic should still be fun. SPARK archived every outcome.

One afternoon, a boy asked Natalia quietly, "How did you get chosen?"

She thought about the blank card, the signature line, the dream.

"I wrote my name when no other sentence worked," she said. "Sometimes that is the bravest line."

At dusk the catalog produced a tiny silver stamp for Natalia. It read INDEX KEEPER and printed a star beside completed return tasks. She laughed when Maya demanded one on her forehead.

"Professional misuse of office," Alana warned.

"Legendary use of office," Maya corrected.

That evening Natalia opened her notebook and copied the return due from the final card again:

Teach the next borrower to write their own name.

She understood now. The catalog did not want followers. It wanted future stewards.

She closed the notebook and looked around the library where friends sorted books, readers whispered, and SPARK hummed softly while updating records.

She had written her name, yes.

Now she would help others write theirs.

Chapter 11 — The Return Festival

To celebrate one full month of balanced wishes, the friends organized the library's first Return Festival. Not a prize ceremony, Natalia insisted. A gratitude ceremony. Every borrower who had completed a return task could share what they gave back and what they learned.

Maya designed banners with twinkling letters: MAGIC THAT COMES FULL CIRCLE. Alana built a giant scoreboard called THE BALANCE WALL, where colored pins tracked categories like Courage, Curiosity, Repair, and Joy. SPARK handled sound, lights, and an adorable robot emcee voice.

The festival filled the atrium with cheerful noise. Rina spoke about raising her hand in class and then inviting a quiet classmate into her game at recess. A college student described returning a wish for better memory by tutoring two younger readers in study habits. An elderly patron explained how wishing for less loneliness had led her to start a weekly storytelling circle.

Each story ended with the same conclusion in different words: giving back made the wish deeper.

Midway through the event, trouble flickered. A new visitor tried to bypass the oath by grabbing cards rapidly and scribbling demands. The catalog stalled, lights flickering uncertainly.

Natalia stepped forward with steady calm. "Please pause. Wishes only work safely with consent to return."

The visitor scoffed. "Rules ruin magic."

Maya crossed her arms boldly. "No, rules keep magic from becoming theft."

Alana added, "Unreturned wishes externalize costs onto everyone else. We have data."

SPARK projected a clear visual of the previous debt storm, complete with glitter explosion metrics.

The visitor looked around at the crowd of borrowers sharing return stories and slowly lowered the card. "I... did not know."

Natalia handed over an oath sheet. "You can still borrow. Start with one wish. Return it fully."

He nodded and wrote a modest request for patience with his younger brother. His return task came back: play one game using his brother's rules. He chuckled despite himself.

When the festival ended, the Balance Wall shone with pins. Curiosity and Joy nearly tied for first. The atrium smelled like paper, tea, and triumph.

SPARK announced final totals: "Wishes granted this month: seventy-two. Returns completed: seventy-two. Community cohesion: excellent."

Maya threw both fists up. "Perfect score!"

Natalia touched the catalog drawer and felt it hum beneath her hand, content and alive. She did not feel like an owner. She felt like a caretaker among many.

That was better.

Chapter 12 — The Last Slot, The Next Name

Winter arrived with silver mornings and windows fogged by warm breath. Drawer Q now opened on schedule each day, calm and dependable. Borrowers signed the oath, made thoughtful wishes, and returned them with growing pride. The system worked not because magic was flawless, but because people practiced repair.

One evening, Natalia found a child waiting by the catalog after closing, clutching a crumpled notebook. Her name was Sami. She looked about seven and very nervous.

"I heard this is where wishes happen," Sami whispered.

"It is," Natalia said. "But here, wishes and responsibility travel together."

Sami nodded hard. "I can be responsible."

She wrote: I wish for courage to read my story out loud.

A tiny moon-shaped clip appeared for her notebook.

RETURN DUE: HELP THE NEXT WRITER BEGIN THEIR FIRST SENTENCE.

Sami smiled with sudden relief. "I can do that too."

Before leaving, she squinted at the lower drawer. "Why is there one empty slot?"

Natalia knelt beside her. In the deepest tray, behind balanced cards and keeper stamps, one narrow compartment indeed remained open. No card inside. Just a slim line engraved in silver:

NEXT INDEX KEEPER: _____

Natalia felt a soft ache of understanding. Stewardship was not forever for one person. It was a torch passed hand to hand.

She called Maya, Alana, and SPARK over. They looked at the empty slot together in thoughtful silence.

"So that is the future line," Alana said.

"Good design," SPARK added. "Succession planning prevents system fragility."

Maya bumped Natalia's shoulder. "You are not going anywhere soon, though."

"No," Natalia said, smiling. "But we can start preparing others."

Over the next weeks they began a Saturday circle for young borrowers: how to phrase wishes, how to spot selfish loopholes, how to complete return tasks with creativity and heart. Sami became the first assistant mentor, proudly helping newcomers write first sentences.

On the final Saturday before spring, Sami read her story aloud to a packed nook. Her voice trembled once, then steadied. When she finished, applause filled the room like sunlight.

Afterward she helped another child begin a first line, exactly as her return task asked.

Natalia checked the card. Green glow. Complete.

The catalog hummed, deep and pleased. Natalia looked at the empty keeper slot and no longer felt pressure. She felt continuity.

She took out the silver stamp, marked the day's final card, and whispered the oath one more time:

Take what you need. Return what you can. Leave it kinder.

Drawer Q slid closed with a soft click, holding not just wishes, but names ready to be written.

THE END